



ACE

ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT



PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL

DEAR PRESIDENT OBAMA

My name is Léandre Poplus, and I am the founder of the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development. I am writing to you because your experience offers a perspective few others can bring to the work we are undertaking. You spent eight years at the highest level of an institution that, for much of this nation's history, was never designed with people who look like us in mind. I come to you respectfully, not simply seeking support, but hoping to draw on what you learned from navigating that institution as we consider how to build something enduring of our own.

I do not approach this work as a constitutional scholar, policymaker, or someone who believes he has every answer. I am simply someone who has spent years asking difficult questions, following the evidence as honestly as I know how, and trying to build something that could materially improve the future of our communities. ACE is the result of that effort. I know there are things I may have missed, assumptions that deserve to be challenged, and areas that people with knowledge and experience beyond my own can strengthen. That is one of the reasons I am placing this work before you.

You are the only former President who has stood at the exact intersection where this initiative lives: the tension between operating inside American systems and carrying the full weight of what those systems have done and continue to do to people of color in this country. You have navigated that tension at the highest level any person can. ACE needs that navigation now.

The Alliance for Collective Empowerment is a 25-year initiative to build a network of self-governing, self-sustaining cities for Black and Native American communities on tribal land protected by sovereign law, funded by community capital, governed by a constitutional framework written by the community it serves.

This is not a movement without a map. The enclosed founding volume spans 22 Titles and more than 1,100 paragraphs, laying out a founding constitution, a 25-year phased development plan, a tribal engagement strategy, healthcare and education systems extending from kindergarten through medical school, a community finance model, a formal tax equity initiative, and a 33.15-million-acre contingency land claim derived from a per-person calculation of the 1865 promise that was never intended to be fulfilled.

We are not asking for your public endorsement. We understand the complexity of your position. What we would value most is your candid assessment of whether this framework is sound and, if



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you believe it is, your guidance on how it might earn the confidence of those whose support will ultimately determine whether it can become a reality.

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

The founding documents of the United States did not accidentally exclude Black and Native people. That exclusion was deliberate, specific, and written into the nation's original framework. We do not dispute that history. What ACE disputes is the assumption that the remedy must be found within the same architecture that produced the exclusion. From our perspective, the system is not simply failing to overcome its original design; it is fulfilling it. For that reason, we are no longer waiting for that structure to become something it was never designed to be. Nor are we asking to reform it.

Much of the activism, legislation, and litigation that came before ACE rested on the belief that the system could be made to serve the people it was designed to exclude-on the hope that if enough laws changed, institutions and eventually hearts would follow. Many of those efforts produced real and hard-won gains, and ACE does not diminish them. However, history has shown us that no act of Congress, no Supreme Court ruling, and no constitutional amendment can legislate what lives in the hearts of the people responsible for carrying it out. The law can change. The person entrusted to enforce it does not have to.

That conclusion is not born of spite or hatred. ACE is choosing, deliberately and without hostility, to build outside the jurisdiction of a constitutional framework that was never written with our communities in mind.

It follows from what the evidence has made plain: the freedom, sovereignty, and dignity Black and Native people deserve cannot be granted by a system designed to deny them. A system built to truly serve our communities must be built by those communities, on their own ground and under their own authority.

Black communities are no strangers to building institutions, wealth, and power of their own. From Reconstruction-era institutions to Greenwood in Tulsa, and later to the organizations and movements targeted by COINTELPRO, history shows that Black self-determination has often been met not simply with resistance, but with deliberate efforts to destroy or dismantle it. ACE was designed in recognition of that history, with the understanding that what we build must be capable not only of serving our communities, but also of enduring any attempts to destroy it from the outside. You understand the workings of that system from a vantage point few people ever will, having spent eight years at its highest level.

Every legal protection in this framework exists because we studied what happened to what came before us and chose to build accordingly. The question we are bringing to you is not whether this vision is necessary. We believe you already know that it is. The question is whether the architecture is sound enough to survive what will come for it. That is why we need your counsel, not your endorsement.



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THE ASK

Will you help us navigate this correctly?

If, after reviewing the enclosed proposal, you believe the framework is serious, legally grounded, and sound, what we would value most is your candid assessment and your guidance on how it might earn the confidence of those whose support will ultimately determine whether it can become a reality.

If you believe it warrants their attention, a private word from you to the right people could open doors we cannot open on our own. We are not asking for your public endorsement, nor are we asking you to carry this effort.

If you have concerns about the framework, we want to hear those just as clearly. Your perspective on what can withstand legal and political scrutiny, where the proposal may be vulnerable, and what we may not yet have considered would be invaluable before we move further.

We will follow up through the Obama Foundation within 90 days of this delivery. If you choose not to respond, we will respect that decision, keep your silence private, and continue the work.

We are not asking you to carry this. We are asking you to tell us whether we are carrying it correctly-and, if we are, how best to carry it forward.

We also recognize the value of trusted perspectives in considering something of this weight. If Michelle has an opportunity to read this with you, we would welcome her perspective as well. Her experience and judgment are ones we would not take lightly.

The founding volume is enclosed. Thank you for your time and consideration.

SUPPORTING LEGAL DOCUMENTATION, AVAILABLE UPON REQUEST

The following documents have been prepared and are available to you upon request:

- **ACE Sovereign Territory Act: Companion Legal Brief v1.3** - Pre-argument legal defense of ACE's contingency land claim across ten states of existing federal public land, grounded in the Continuity Doctrine and the Federally Recognized Indian Tribe List Act of 1994.
- **ACE Submission to the United Nations CERD v1.1** - Formal civil society submission to the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination's active General Recommendation on reparations for chattel enslavement, filed June 2026.

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